

“I sell my eggs and butter from home for \$200 a month. Does it not sound well ... But in what? **In Confederate money.** *Hélas!*”

MARY CHESNUT, *A DIARY FROM DIXIE*, SEPTEMBER 19, 1864

Volunteer aid societies

Within months of the firing on Fort Sumter, almost 20,000 local aid societies organized in both the Union and the Confederacy. Many, especially in the South, withered and died as wartime hardships disrupted their activities, but thousands persisted. The societies and their national counterparts supplied soldiers in the field with homeknit clothing, jams and preserves, writing supplies, newspapers, Bibles, and books.

Most of these organizations were run locally by wives and daughters of soldiers, and aimed at the physical and emotional comfort of their menfolk. Often they raised money through fairs and bazaars to purchase items to be sent to the soldiers. These philanthropic events were highlights on the social calendars of Northern and Southern communities, and in the larger cities thousands turned out to buy homemade goods produced by the societies' members. Raffles, benefit balls, and musical entertainment also were popular fundraising methods. Infused with patriotism, good will, and religious fervor, these activities kept the war at the forefront of peoples' minds, especially in the North, where the physical effects of the conflict were minimal and only the absence of military-age males showed that life had changed.